



Sun City Hilton Head

COMMUNITY ASSOCIATION

Turf Grass: What to Expect

Sun City Hilton Head homes are built on pre-graded and stabilized pads, as environmentally mandated. These pads and the surrounding property must be stabilized to avoid eroding into natural areas. Stabilization is achieved by hydroseeding, which includes a mixture of aggressively growing turf types and weed seeds. Weeds from hydroseed continuously emerge over the first 12-18 months on newly installed lawns.

The information below will explain the limited services provided after the new installation and establishment period of a sodded Bermuda grass lawn.

Bermuda Grass Overview

Bermuda grass is a warm temperature, drought tolerant and durable turf. It requires a minimum of six hours of direct sunlight, daily. Areas that do not receive six hours of direct sunlight will thin out over time and may require re-sodding or patching. Most lawns, golf courses and athletic fields in the Southeast are of the Bermuda species due to its resiliency and drought tolerance.

Dormancy

Bermuda grass goes dormant in the fall and winter months, changing from green to a yellow/brown color. Sod tends to have a weaker first spring if installed during the cooler months (September through March) because the new root system is more likely to have direct contact with cold air and frost. This delays the time it takes for the grass to firmly attach to the soil.

Spring “Green-Up”

If a late frost occurs, it will delay the regenerative process and transformation from dormancy to green by weeks. When daytime air temperatures stay consistently above 80 degrees, a fast transformation of turf will occur.

Fungus and Insects

In the Lowcountry, fungus and insects can present turf issues. Temperature swings and damp soil are the main cause of fungus. Insects such as fire ants, army worms and mole crickets are commonly treated in this area.

Soil Conditions

Most of the soil in Sun City is clay. Clay soil holds moisture longer than loamy or sandy soil and requires less irrigation. As a result, over-irrigating and heavy rainfall may result in prolonged pooling and turf destruction. This is common in areas that do not receive full sun, such as the area in between homes. The water-retaining characteristics of clay soil make it easy for lawn mowers to cause unintentional damage to turf as crews servicing lawns cannot know how saturated the clay soil is from one house to the next.

Irrigation

Managing an irrigation system is very important! Each Sun City home is equipped with a rain sensor which is activated when a predetermined amount of rain has accumulated. The sensor will turn the system off until the collected rain has evaporated. Sensors should be cleaned of debris, pollen and spider webs annually. In addition, residents are urged to coordinate watering times of side yards with their neighbors. During the spring and summer months, most side yards require no more than two (2) minutes of watering per week. The largest inhibitor of lawn services, and a contributor to rutting, is turf saturation from rain, over-irrigating or a combination of both.

Fertilization and Weed Control

Applied slow-phased release fertilizer begins feeding turf when soil surface temperatures consistently reach 55 degrees and continues to provide nutrients through August. Advanced polymer-coated products allow all necessary nutrients to be deposited in one efficient application. Depending on weather conditions during the growing season, supplements such as iron, magnesium and other micronutrients are applied to help the new sod. Both pre and post-emergent herbicides are applied to treat weeds. Newer sod experiences more weeds than established yards, however, no treatments are applied before the seams have grown in to prevent herbicides from direct contact with root systems. Once the seams have grown in it is considered a good benchmark that indicates the sod has rooted in and it is safe to apply herbicide.

Granular and spray pre-emergent applications typically occur in October-November and February-March. Depending on conditions, a mid-summer treatment may be applicable. Pre-emergent is not good for root systems, which leaves a short window of opportunity to treat relatively new sod. For instance, lawns typically installed between April and August receive routine pre-emergent applications, whereas lawns installed in early fall and winter may miss both pre-emergent treatments.